

The 9-Level Roadmap

Each level below is one sitting — 20 to 60 minutes. Do them in order; every level makes the next one easier. Commands assume Claude Code is installed (`npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`).

Lvl1 Terminal

The build: fix one real bug by describing it.

```
cd your-project && claude  
> the login form lets empty emails through — find it and fix it
```

Watch it read files, edit and run tests. Approve each step. That trust loop is the foundation.

Lvl2 Memory

The build: write CLAUDE.md in 15 minutes.

```
> /init    # Claude drafts CLAUDE.md from your repo — then edit it
```

Keep it under a page: stack, folder layout, naming rules, the 3 commands you run daily. Delete anything Claude could figure out itself.

Lvl3 Commands

The build: learn the context trio, make one custom command.

```
> /context  # see what fills the window  
> /compact # shrink it
```

```
# custom: save ".claude/commands/standup.md" containing your standup template  
> /standup
```

Custom commands are just markdown files. That's the whole trick.

Lvl 4 Skills

The build: package the workflow you repeat most.

```
# .claude/skills/review/SKILL.md – your review checklist, your rules  
> /review src/api/orders.ts
```

A skill = a playbook file Claude loads on demand. Mine run my whole content system.

Lvl 5 MCP

The build: connect ONE server you'd actually use.

```
claude mcp add # pick one: Notion, Gmail, Postgres, your browser
```

One good connection beats ten idle ones. "Read my Notion roadmap and draft this week's plan" is the moment MCP clicks.

Lvl 6 Subagents

The build: hand off one long job.

```
> use a subagent to audit every API route for missing auth checks,  
and report back a table
```

Your main thread stays clean while the heavy search runs in its own context.

Lvl 7 Hooks

The build: one guard + one notification.

```
# settings.json → hooks: block "rm -rf", and ping you when Claude finishes  
# ask Claude itself: "add a hook that blocks destructive commands"
```

Hooks are the seatbelt that makes the higher levels safe to automate.

Lvl 8 **Headless**

The build: put Claude in CI once.

```
claude -p "review this diff for regressions, exit non-zero if risky"
```

Run it in a GitHub Action on every PR. Now the review happens whether you remember or not.

Lvl 9 **Routines**

The build: one scheduled morning job.

```
> /schedule every weekday 6:00 – triage my inbox, draft replies,  
  leave a 5-line brief
```

This is the level where the business starts without you. Start with ONE routine and live with it a week before adding more.

Where founders should stop: levels 1–5 cover 90% of a founder's real work. Only climb to 6–9 when a specific repeated pain demands it — automation you don't need is just maintenance you do.

One level per sitting. Nine sittings from now, it's a different job.

